

Emigrant Letter from 1890

Translated into modern and readable English (Illustrated Edition v4)

Original Date: April 18, 1890

Location: Liverpool, England

Sender: D. (sent to parents)

Dear Parents,

I have now arrived safely in Liverpool. We did not end up traveling with the Inman Line as we had intended, because their ship 'City of New York' was damaged some time ago. It has been taken out of service and will not leave Liverpool until May 2nd. The ship offered to us instead was small, only about 4,000 tons. Therefore, we decided to switch to the Cunard Line to secure passage on one of their best ships, the 'Aurania', an 8,000-ton vessel that departs from here tomorrow, Saturday the 19th.



Figure 1: The passenger steamship S/S Aurania of the Cunard Line at sea. Built in 1883, the vessel combined steam power with masts for auxiliary sails (Illustration from Cassier's Magazine, 1895).

In Gothenburg, Hedberg advised us to buy second-class tickets for the voyage between Gothenburg and Hull, as he claimed third class on that route would be terribly unpleasant, with passengers from all lines and emigrants packed together in utter confusion. However, we decided to try third class anyway to get used to hardships, and so we did.

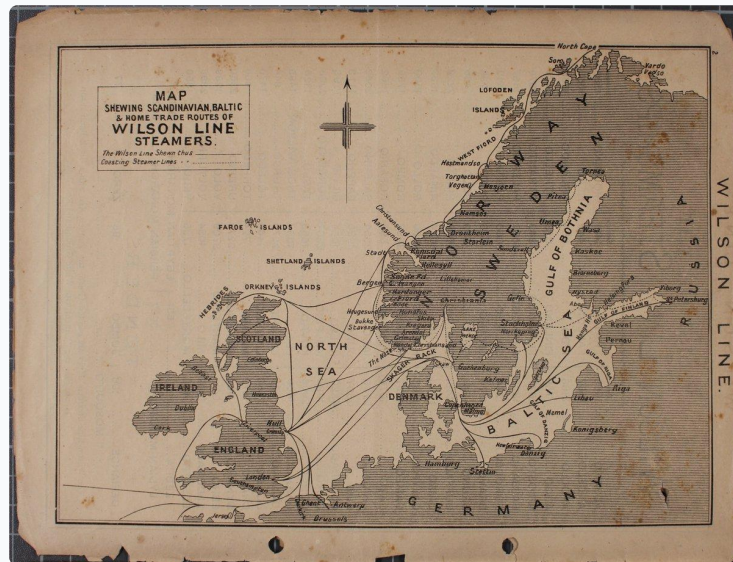


Figure 5: Historical route map of the North Sea showing Wilson Line's shipping connections between Great Britain, Scandinavia, and Continental Europe during the late 19th century.

The third-class passengers—including a large group of Finns who smelled very foul, numbering over 200 people in total—were placed on the steerage deck in a single massive room. Bunks were arranged side by side in two tiers, with narrow aisles and low ceilings. The sleeping quarters down there were naturally the worst part of the whole ship due to the Finns, who are very untidy. We stayed up on deck as long as possible and tried to sleep there, but the fierce wind made it impossible to remain all night. We began to freeze, the ship rolled heavily, and it rained occasionally, so we were ultimately forced to go below deck and lie down for a few hours after all.

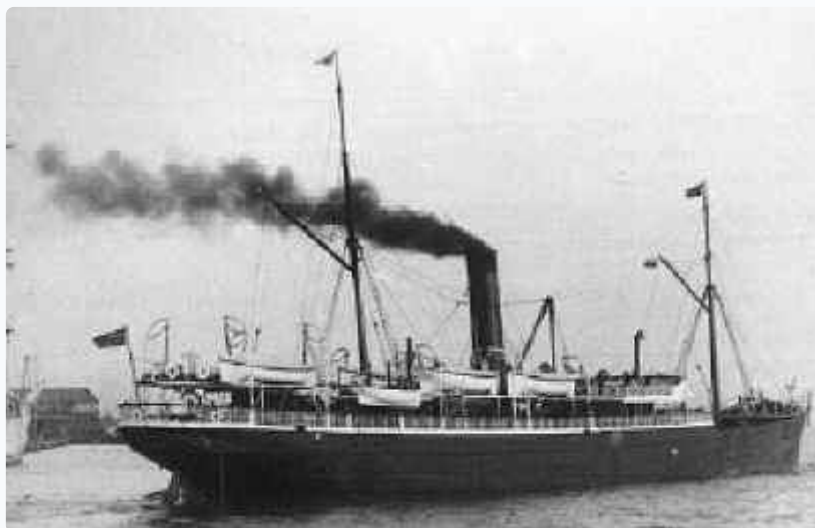


Figure 4: One of Wilson Line's steamships intended for freight and passenger transport, circa 1880.

During the first 24 hours, despite a rather strong wind, we had a side-tailwind, so the wind and rolling were not felt too badly. Nevertheless, most of the passengers, especially all the women, were seasick even then. On the second day, the ship changed course and we encountered a heavy crosswind. Since the wind had

increased significantly, the rolling became severe, making it difficult to even stand on one's feet. By then, nearly everyone was more or less seasick, and the scene below deck defies description. But imagine—neither Arvid nor I felt the slightest bit of seasickness during the entire voyage! We were therefore very pleased and enjoyed a great appetite for our packed lunches. We also ate some of the food provided on board, such as tea, which was quite good, some coffee, and meat and potatoes—all served in the simple style of Sannahed, a manner we were already accustomed to. Furthermore, we had enough provisions and utensils in our food baskets that we didn't have to eat with our fingers (we had purchased quite a few utensils in Gothenburg). Because we only slept below deck for a few hours during each of the two nights, we have so far had the pleasure of avoiding bedbugs and fleas. Hopefully, it won't be too bad on the Atlantic either, where the cabins accommodate about 20 people and we hope to be lucky enough to get a reasonably decent group.

Upon arrival in Hull, our trunks were opened, but our other travel effects were not subjected to customs duties. The inspection seemed to be purely pro forma, and no one had to pay any duty. Afterwards, we were taken to a sort of barracks for emigrants, where we were given coffee and sandwiches and were able to wash and freshen up. This barracks was newly built and is never used at night when no emigrants stay there; it was very neat, clean, and airy. Immediately afterward, we boarded a train right next to the building and traveled to Liverpool. The train was a special extra train, and the third-class carriages had soft, padded cushions, just as good as second class in Sweden. Consequently, we traveled quite comfortably, going directly from Hull to Liverpool in 5 hours without stopping along the way, except at one station to wait for an oncoming train. It was a pity that most of the journey took place during the night, so we did not see much of the countryside we passed through. We left Hull at 6 PM and arrived just after 11 PM.



Figure 3: A British steam locomotive with passenger carriages on the railway line between Hull and Liverpool, circa 1890.

But before it grew completely dark, we had the opportunity to observe the cleanliness and orderliness everywhere in the countryside. There were straight fields without stones in the soil, enclosed by well-trimmed and well-maintained hawthorn hedges. No wooden fences like the ones in Sweden were to be seen anywhere. Everything was neat, even, graceful, and polished—such as is hardly ever seen in Sweden.

Upon our arrival in Liverpool on Thursday night, we were taken to the shipping line's emigrant hotel and put up there; it was clean. In our room, there are six of us sharing four beds. The food has been quite good. The best part of all was that in Hull we got rid of all the Finns, as they went with another line, the Guion Line. From the start, we joined forces with a company of pleasant people from Värmland and Bergslagen so that we could jointly keep an eye on our belongings. Here in Liverpool, a whole mass of emigrants is waiting to

depart, some having been here for half a week. But since there weren't many of us arriving from Gothenburg—which is apparently always the case for Tuesday departures—I hope we will be able to board the Aurania tomorrow, Saturday. When the ships cannot hold more than a certain limited number, the rest must wait until the next one departs.

Liverpool is a very large city, said to be twice the size of Stockholm. The shops and everything in that regard, as well as the stations here and all along the way, are far grander than Stockholm itself. What caught our eye immediately were the massive cart-horses, the so-called English 'elephant-horses.' They were real giants in size, and all the work wagons are constructed with a thickness that is, to say the least, like the undercarriage of a threshing machine back home. For such a wagon loaded with sacks, bales, or other goods, two or three such horses walk in a single file line, one in front of the other. The cabs consist of large covered gigs where the driver sits at the back, almost on the roof. The weight of the gig is balanced so that the horse does not have to bear the weight of the shafts; these sit high up on the horse's side, secured with a strap under the belly, so that the gig rather lifts the horse. Some of the largest streets are paved with wood. I am sitting in a large dining hall with many, many tables and benches in rows, writing this.



Figure 2: Bustling traffic with horse-drawn cabs and work wagons on a cobbled street in Liverpool during the 1890s.

Your affectionate son,
D.

P.S. Has Miss Ölander returned, and how was it with her father?

If you write, address the letters to: *Los Angeles, poste restante, California, North America.*

I received the package with the pipe an hour before I left Gothenburg. I didn't have time to open it until we were at sea. That was when I first saw the letters to Filemon, which I thus brought along.

In Gothenburg, we visited the Hedbergs twice and the Walqvists once. Give them my regards. When the steamship 'Dominas' departed, the Hedbergs were down at the dock along with Filemon, waving goodbye.